

The Adult Brain

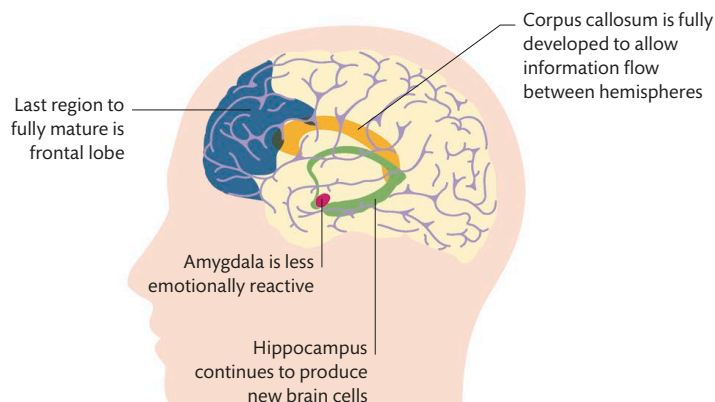
Human brains continue to change and mature throughout early adulthood, as unused connections are pruned away. This makes the brain more efficient but also less flexible.

Adult life

A fully developed, mature brain is equipped to handle all the competing demands and pressures of adult life, from work and finances to relationships and health.

PARENTHOOD

A new mother's brain and body are awash with hormones such as oxytocin, driving her to care for her baby. Looking at her infant triggers the brain's reward pathways, and her amygdala becomes more active, scanning for danger. Men's brains are affected by parenthood, too, but only if they spend a lot of time with their baby. The brains of men who are primary caregivers of an infant go through similar changes to women's, and these changes appear to be very similar to falling in love.



Mature brains

Full myelination (the sheathing of axons in myelin) allows information to flow freely, but the process is completed only in a person's late 20s. The last brain region to finish maturing is the frontal lobe, which is responsible for judgment and inhibition. Compared to children and teenagers, adults are better able to regulate their emotions and control their impulses. They can use their experiences to better predict the outcomes of their actions and how they may make other people feel.